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INTRODUCTION

Gender and public space

Pumla Dineo Gqola, Iromi Perera, Shilpa Phadke, Nazanin Shahrokni, Sofia Zaragocin*, Shivani Satija and Anandita Ghosh

The gendered dimensions of public space have been researched and written about extensively, particularly in the 21st century. Scholarship and activism have focused on the ideological, spatial, and methodological aspects from the vantage point of multiple disciplines including but not limited to geography, anthropology, sociology, literature, architecture, history, and the inter-disciplinary fields of urban and rural studies, cultural studies, media studies, gender studies, and sexuality studies. This special issue of *Gender & Development* set out to contribute to this expanding field of gender and public space with all its contestations and heterogeneities. The effort has been to engage with gender and public space as a theoretical field, as a locus of methodological experiments, as a site of collective politics, and as a dynamic location of bodily, literary, and creative labour.

This collection brings together multiple theoretical approaches and foregrounds the experiences of marginalised groups, while reflecting on public activisms that strive towards inclusive and participatory public spaces based on solidarity, care, and citizenship. The articles in this collection explore urban, suburban, and rural public spaces, neighbourhoods, parks, streets, digital platforms, university campuses, plazas, sugarcane fields, and more. They examine the physical, symbolic, and affective dimensions of infrastructures such as swings, benches, bridges, walls, streets, verandahs, public toilets, and parking lots – with the multiple restrictions and possibilities they offer. They delve into concerns of intersectional identities across religion, caste, sexuality and gender, class, race, ethnicity, and citizenship status that shape gendered experiences in these public spaces.

Contributors to this issue include academics, practitioners, and activists from varied disciplinary locations and professional fields. The contributions span countries such as Algeria, Argentina, Australia, Chile, Egypt, Ethiopia, Greece, India, Indonesia, Iran, Jordan, Kenya, Lebanon, Pakistan, Palestine, Mexico, Morocco, Peru, South Africa, Spain, Sri Lanka, Syria, Tunisia, Turkey, United Kingdom, and Uruguay.

The contributions collectively document and analyse the often-restricted access to public space experienced by women, gender-diverse peoples, and other marginalised groups, revealing how spatial dynamics intersect with overarching structures of domination and oppression. Harnessing a range of research methodologies and creative strategies, including auto-ethnography, art, literary and film criticism, and archival work,

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these texts allow a multi-layered theoretical and activist engagement with public space. They also reflect on the transformative potential of reclaiming public spaces through movement, writing, art, and protest by historically marginalised groups. Through these acts of re-territorialisation and resignification, marginalised individuals assert their right to exist and thrive within spaces historically designed to exclude them.

This special issue is collectively edited by Pumla Dineo Gqola, Iromi Perera, Shilpa Phadke, Nazanin Shahrokni, and Sofia Zaragocin who are reputed academics and practitioners representing the fields of sociology; decolonial feminist geography; literary, media, and cultural studies; political activism; and urban planning across the regions of South Asia, South-West Asia, Southern Africa, and Latin America. Together they share a deep political commitment to inclusive, accessible, and feminist public spaces. Shivani Satija and Anandita Ghosh as lead editors of the journal worked closely with the invited editors to assure a collective editorial approach. The editing process was participatory and collaborative, while regional inclusivity and just representation were key values shared by all editors.

This introduction is organised along six sections: (1) Navigating fear, safety, and surveillance in public spaces; (2) Porous boundaries and questions of liminal spaces, bodies, and experiences; (3) Everyday mapping and methods to make *other* spatialities; (4) 'Feeling designed out': urban planning and gendered design; (5) Cultivating solidarity, care, fun, and friendships in physical and digital spaces; and (6) Challenging erasures through art and creative theorisations. These divisions are inevitably porous, leak into each other, and are far from exhaustive. Our choice of themes around which to anchor this introduction draws from the papers in this issue as well as the debates in the field. We hope this introduction will serve as a map to navigate the issue as well as generate more interdisciplinary and cross-regional research and writing on gender and public space.

Navigating fear, safety, and surveillance in public spaces

Neoliberal policies across the world have facilitated the privatisation of all kinds of spaces thus reshaping urban and rural landscapes. Neoliberalism creates spatial inequalities and exacerbates the exclusion of citizens from what should be *public* spaces. Public spaces, infrastructures, and services around the world, particularly in the global South(s), have been adversely impacted by neoliberal economic and public policies, and planning mechanisms characterised by speculative capitalism and privatisation of public institutions and services. These have negatively affected marginalised communities through structural dispossession and physical displacements, although in specifically different ways across political and historical contexts (Abeyasekera et al. 2019; Burte and Kamath 2023; Butcher and Velayutham 2009; Fawaz 2009). Marginalised and impoverished (yet high-value) neighbourhoods are being sanitised, commodified, restructured, and homogenised through large-scale redevelopment projects with serious implications on the lives and livelihoods of poor communities (Cooper, Hubbard, and Lees 2020; Kundu and Satija 2023).

The fragmentation of communities due to these displacements and dispossessions results in the loss of infrastructures of care and kinship cultivated over decades

(Perera 2023). The gendered, casteist, and racialised implications of these sociospatial ruptures result in further control and regulation over certain women's and girls' bodies (upper caste, middle class, white) due to perceived lack of safety; and stigmatisation and criminalisation of working-class men, trans persons, and sex workers (Cahill et al. 2019; Kent-Stoll 2020; Phadke 2013; Phadke, Khan, and Ranade 2011).

Phadke, Khan, and Ranade (2011), in their book *Why Loiter? Women and Risk on Mumbai Streets*, have argued that neoliberalism facilitates a 'discourse of safety' that renders not just women but also other marginal citizens as outsiders to public space, pitting them against each other. This produces hierarchies and divisions based on gender, caste, and religion which shape, regulate, and govern access, belonging, and behaviour in public space. Carina Listerborn (2016) contends that planning and urban dynamics use the 'safety discourse' that originates in radical feminisms from the 1970s, in ways that result in a contemporary depoliticised and co-opted version that only responds to privileged white women in western contexts, without addressing the structures that produce situations of gendered and racialised fear, insecurity, and violence. Listerborn's (2016) proposal is to not dismiss the neoliberal safety discourse entirely but rather to reframe it, considering fears stemming from the lived and everyday experience of *othered* bodies in space. In material terms, this means promoting planning practices and praxis that will reposition fear in ways that engage directly with antiracist feminist perspectives (Listerborn 2016) and reflect on how violence as well as fear of violence is defined in the context of the public.

Gqola (2023), in her book *Female Fear Factory: Unravelling Patriarchy's Cultures of Violence*, reveals the role of patriarchy in instilling, sustaining, and unleashing a gendered form of fear in order to enact control. This understanding rests on recognising the ways in which fear is simultaneously an intimately experienced factor and a political regulatory mechanism for control, subjugation, oppression, and terrorisation of certain populations. As such, then, it relies on a system of logics that naturalises it through socialising gendered beings into 'fluency' in order for its targets to be able to decipher their place as either empowered or disposable in a violent patriarchal structure. Fluency is required in the construction of people into the 'social category of the female' which includes all women as well as gender and sexual minorities. This way, the factory regulates the conditions under which women may access publicness, visibility, and retain such visibility (Gqola 2015; Ligaga 2020). Fluency relies on quick seamless communication of threat in public and private, creating an unquestioned understanding of where one belongs, thus conditioning women to 'know their place'. Shahrokni's 2019 work, *Women in Place: The Politics of Gender Segregation in Iran*, similarly explores the conditional access of women to public spaces provided by the state, influenced by a blend of religious considerations, state decorum, neoliberal imperatives, and shifting geopolitical alliances. These factors culminate in a state strategy that grants women conditional and controlled access to public spaces, while appearing to be liberal (Shahrokni 2014, 2019).

Further, safety is inevitably tied to a politics of respectability and patriarchal protectionism, the consequence of which is often the restriction of women's mobility. This discourse of safety forecloses women's opportunities for pleasure and leisure by

perceiving women as being potentially at risk of violence in public spaces and concomitantly disallowing them from taking chosen risks (Phadke 2005, 2007). Access to public spaces intended for leisure especially, is often attended by fears of vandalism anchored on principles of exclusion. In this process, violence against women is defined in narrow ways as spontaneous violence committed by strangers in public space. This narrow perception disregards the everyday structured violence that women face in their homes in the form of restrictions on their mobility, which are often not considered violence, but rather benevolent protectionism or even expressions of love (Phadke 2010). It is in these contexts that the global response to a lack of safety for women in public spaces, which has been to increase surveillance, must be read. The increasing use of surveillance technologies, such as CCTV cameras and mobile safety apps, do little to address the problems created by at best gender-ignorant or at worst sexist planning and policies that function to restrict women's access to public space. Such surveillance is often instituted in the absence of infrastructures such as public transport, street lighting, and public toilets that would create a welcoming atmosphere for women. Further, these measures of safety do little to ameliorate the fear of physical and sexual violence and harassment that is ever-present for marginalised bodies in public spaces, whether they use these for leisure or to pursue their livelihoods.

The 'theatrical performance' of this threat of violence – in other words the female fear factory – thus, shapes public spaces, their access, and their (im)possibilities in markedly gendered ways, as well as the definition of who matters and who does not (Gqola 2015, 2023). The article in this issue by Bina Fernandez stages multiple encounters and negotiations of the female fear factory as well as the ways in which its intersections with ethnicity, nationality, and migration produce proliferating dangerous effects. In one story, a Lebanese man pours a bucket of water over the author's recognisably brown body at an ostensibly open beach, Baida Beach in Beirut, while she was walking with an Ethiopian domestic worker. She narrates this story having analysed the ways in which her participants highlight the particular gender-, race-, and ethnic-specific policing of their leisure and pleasure in public spaces, and how occupation of public spaces makes them targets of violence. Fear also seeps in through the thinly walled abodes that sugarcane farming couples call home in India's western region of Marathwada, as demonstrated in Reetika Revathy Subramanian's article. These walls cannot contain the sounds associated with the routine, uninterrupted physical abuse of wives. This communication of women's unsafety rhymes with these women's decision to move in public in groups for better protection against a fear of 'snakes, animals, and even drunk men'.

Tightening of control over certain bodies and regulation of their movement by the state, social, and religious norms is another way in which marginalised bodies feel at risk. Amaya Perez-Brumer, Ernesto Cuba, Mariangela Castro-Arteaga, Julien Brisson, and Leyla Huerta in this issue discuss sex-based COVID-19 mobility restriction policies in Peru and the resultant increase in fear of violence amongst trans communities. The article provides a brief context of the increasing military and police presence and surveillance over public spaces in order to curtail political protest and curb dissent, resulting in violation of civil rights and deepening of social and spatial segregation. Angbeen Abbas's

essay shines light on how securitisation shapes and affects women's engagement with public spaces in Lahore, Pakistan. The essay stresses that moral policing by the police often forces women to contemplate whether to go out at all, and they avoid going out dressed in certain ways or with men to whom they are unrelated. Mahima Taneja provides examples from a low-income riverbank settlement in Agra, India to show how social norms and state control conjoin, preventing women, particularly those who are young and unmarried, from accessing public spaces. The communities that the paper engages with are both Hindu and Muslim, which creates particular, additional fractures and anxieties. The affective environment (*mahaul*) of certain physical spaces like the riverbank and parks in the neighbourhood is designated as 'bad' or dangerous due to the possibility of harassment as well as transgressive love. Thus, many residents perceive these spaces as threatening. Judyannet Muchiri examines the worlds of young women in relation to access to civic participation in Nairobi, Rift Valley, and Nyanza in Kenya. Muchiri uses the term safe/r spaces to suggest, 'spaces cannot be fully safe for everyone at any given time, but they can be safe/r' and visualises safety as a process rather than something that can be completely achieved. Surveillance of young women and girls is highlighted in the articles by Olivia Theocharides-Feldman and Julia King, and Garyfallia Katsavounidou, in the UK and Greece, resulting in a constant feeling of being watched, of feeling like not belonging, of feeling out of place. Besides addressing the overarching question of safety in relation to urban policy and planning, these contributions investigate the emotions that lie embedded within it – fear, judgement, shame, 'unbelonging', and the spaces and situations where these are most felt.

There are particular public spaces where reflections around safety and lack thereof intensify, such as the street. The complex nature of streets as posing both possibilities and challenges for women is what brings together several pieces in this issue. Streets serve as arenas of liberation, earning livelihoods, political participation, and forging connections within their communities. Yet, these same spaces are often fraught with harassment and intimidation, perpetuating feelings of insecurity and exclusion. This is illustrated in Hanna Moges Lemma and Ceridwen Spark's article where they explore the ambiguities of belonging. For these Ethiopian migrant women in Melbourne, Australia, the streets of Footscray represent a paradoxical dichotomy – a place of both belonging and alienation, where the quest for inclusion is met with ongoing feelings of displacement. Elizabeth Dessie reflects on how sex workers operating in the streets of Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, were unlikely to report sexual violence experienced from clients since these complaints would not be taken seriously. Further, many of the clients were civil servants, encounters with whom often tended to be intimidating and disrespectful.

Anna Bednarczyk further demonstrates the contradictory character of streets in Argentina, as sites of gendered fear as well as collective political mobilisation. María Ávila and Alejandro Zamora offer a radical resignification of the capitalist and exclusive meaning and purposes of streets and other urban public spaces in Mexico's cities through collectives of women cyclists.

Streets also constitute sites for economic empowerment as well as violence and competition for resources and protection. This dichotomy is depicted in Dessie's article: sex

workers navigate the streets seeking to alleviate economic strains, only to find that the very agents entrusted with their protection, such as the police, pose threats to their safety and security. Khadija Aftab, Fouzia Sadaf, Abida Sharif, and Ayesha Aqeel Ahmed demonstrate similar feelings of fear, anxiety, shame, and despair expressed by 'lower'-caste Christian women sanitary workers in public spaces in Lahore who are subjected to caste-based discrimination and humiliation on a daily basis while accessing public services like transport and health care. Both sanitary work and sex work are stigmatised and precarious forms of feminised labour. Here a labour regime characterised by class and caste, and gender regime come together to reinforce each other. The performance of these intimate and stigmatised types of labour is most often in the public and exposes the bodies that perform it to violence, discrimination, and exclusion.

In the Indian context too, such stigmatised labour is often linked to caste. Meena Gopal (2012) points out that 'lower'-caste women are inevitably relegated to caste-defined services that are often exploitative and stigmatised. Of these, sex work is considered most stigmatised and can be traced to the historical and systematic upper-caste sexual violence on the bodies of Dalit and Bahujan women who were considered as 'public property', devoid of respectability and agency (Irudayam, Mangubhai, and Lee, 2011; Chakravarti 2018 [2003]). Gopal (2013) examines the 'troubled connection' between sexuality, caste, and labour in the wake of the ban on bar dancing in Maharashtra, India, which revealed ideological fractures among feminists over questions of caste, right to livelihood, and agency. Oppressed caste women are often compelled to access public spaces for economic and livelihood reasons despite the narratives of danger around them. Yet, even as they traverse these spaces, they are doubly outsiders both by caste and gender. Many stigmatised occupations such as rag picking and toilet cleaning do not even offer the anonymity of not being caste marked even in cities. These caste-d bodies then inhabit the public but do not belong to it.

Historically, caste is spatially mapped. The design and plan of the village is to segregate castes in ways that usually have the oppressed castes living outside the actual village, with restrictions on where they can go and which resources, like wells, they can use. Guru (2012) argues that though 'modernity' and 'urbanity' compel the discursive practices of caste, including untouchability, to play out in subtler, less-obvious ways, these continue in insidious and 'subtle' ways, especially within the privacy of the domestic realm. In the public realm, Guru avers that social pressure forces the privileged castes to 'don universal masks' (*ibid*., 220), but the domestic sphere is the space of sovereignty where privileged castes reinforce their caste identities and assert purity and pollution taboos and practices. Space then is relevant for the ways in which caste is enacted, and though it might be hidden in public, it is nevertheless there buried, and can be archaeologically excavated.

Some articles in this issue draw attention to how spatial and mobility practices shape ways in which *other* bodies can transit, reclaim, and re-imagine safety and fear. Acts of blending in or standing out are strategies used by marginalised individuals and groups to negotiate and claim basic needs. Perez-Brumer et al. discussed strategies used by trans persons in Lima to navigate the sex-based COVID-19 restriction policies, and

access public spaces and services by presenting the gender identity that would allow them access to public space, or going out with women family members or friends in groups and trying to 'blend' in. Kai Mata, Hamzah Faraz Karamat, Chandrika Yogarajah, and Wikke Jansen discuss strategies used by queer communities to navigate risk and violence in Indonesia, Sri Lanka, and Pakistan. One term deployed by the authors that encapsulates these strategies in the context of the Khwaja Sira community in Pakistan is Faris Khan's 'translucent citizenship' (p. 381) – where strategies of visibility and lack thereof are mobilised as needed. Some of the coping strategies that women cab drivers use to negotiate and work in public spaces in Spain include avoiding night shifts (trading income for safety) and, in some cases, choosing which destinations they take clients, as presented in the article by Belén Martínez Caparrós. In Abbas's essay based in Lahore, Pakistan, women tend to self-surveil and choose not to step out, or map out and plan routes before stepping out. Dessie's participants in her article on sex workers in Ethiopia discussed a range of coping mechanisms while working on the streets. For instance, they preferred going to hotels where the staff knew them and avoided getting into clients' cars. When faced with vindictive behaviour from clients, these women were sometimes forced to disguise themselves or move to a different space/geographical location to stay safe.

Patriarchal, casteist, and racialised discourses of fear are thus mobilised to dictate and limit women's presence and mobility in public spaces, to subject them to surveillance ostensibly to 'protect' them, as well as stigmatise certain bodies, labour, and spaces which render public spaces unequal, exclusionary, inaccessible, and even hostile for many. The contributions to this issue suggest that these exclusions operate across regions and cultural contexts though there may be specificities of form and content. Challenging the ways in which fear and the desire for safety are used to exclude women and other marginal bodies from the public will involve actively resisting these normative framings.

Porous boundaries and questions of liminal spaces, bodies, and experiences

The distinction between public and private spheres, once taken for granted, has been complexly interrogated and is now understood widely to be fluid and resisting neat categorisation. As boundaries between public and private realms blur and face continuous challenge, the very essence of what defines 'public' undergoes a transformative flux. In this context, can we even talk of an 'essence' in relation to the public? Concomitantly, how do we define the public if we include digital spaces, and reflect on the idea of digital publics? What might constitute 'publicness' if we include social media as a space of engagement and resistance?

Gendered and feminist understandings of the spatial stem not just from the fields of feminist geography and feminist urban studies but, as evident in this special issue, deploy other theoretical frameworks, such as engaging Black Feminist Geographies with feminist art and philosophy in Jana Vosloo's article, and queering infrastructure through trans feminist geographies, art, and activisms in Noah Lubinsky and B Lee-Harrison Aultma's article. Many papers in this issue utilise feminist, queer, and trans geographies to interrogate binary understandings of public and private, care and paid work, male and female,

and sex and gender, to produce alternative decolonial place-based feminist knowledge(s). These articles show that theoretical discussions that normally would occur mostly within the field of feminist geography or feminist urban studies in western contexts have now expanded to other regions of the world, and from distinct perspectives. They also lead us to further question and research: how are these other theoretical engagements and non-western contexts shaping long-standing feminist debates on public/private space.

Fernandez documents how the Ethiopian migrant workers in Lebanon re-configure the public–private boundaries and create a sense of 'home' in otherwise hostile and exclusionary public spaces. She explores how this reconfiguration contributes to the formation of what she refers to as 'migrant counterpublics'. Lemma and Spark's piece on Ethiopian migrants in Footscray, a gentrifying suburb in Melbourne, highlights how migrants, in their effort to create a sense of home, look outside their homes. Home (as an idea, image, meaning) is reconstructed through their visits to grocery stores (which carry Ethiopian products), hairdressers, street walks, and talks with other Ethiopian women. Similarly, Iswarya Priya Jagannathan zooms in on women homeworkers in the small town of Ambur in Southern India to understand how they access 'public' entities through their '*thinna*': a porch/verandah-like structure at the entrance of the house that is located neither outside nor inside the home. The article argues that the *thinna* assumes the location of 'a quasi-public space' even as it is 'spatially attached to a private home' and, in doing so, it facilitates some measure of participation in the public. Moving us to Marathwada, a historically drought-affected and caste-ridden region in Maharashtra, India, Subramanian reflects on the ways in which migrant labourers working on sugarcane fields harvest what she refers to as 'breathing spaces' in shared kitchens outside their makeshift homes, on their way to relieve themselves in open fields, and on the tractor-trailers that ferry them from one sugar field to another, forming friendships and inter-generational alliances. Taneja explores the experiences of women in a low-income riverside settlement in Northern India, who come together on cots in shared courtyards or rooftops, which she refers to as their 'enclosed outside' where, similar to sugarcane field workers, women create their own 'breathing spaces', opportunities for sociality, leisure, and conversation. The concept of 'in-between' space, labour, bodies, and 'enclosed' or 'controlled' public spaces in the form of courtyard, roofs, and *thinnas* present a kind of disruption of the public–private binary and are conceptualised across many articles.

Public restrooms and bathrooms as gendered sites (Cofield and Doan 2021) also present as vulnerable spaces especially for transgender and gender non-normative groups whose presence is perceived as a threat to sex-segregated spaces arising from queer and transphobia, and can be traced to racism and ableism (McGuire, Anderson, and Michaels 2022; Weeks 2016). Connecting critical perspectives of design, planning, and feminist geography with public restrooms have primarily been present in Anglophone literature and for western contexts, hence the Argentinian case study presented by Griselda Flesler and Carolina Spataro concerning gender-neutral bathrooms in public university settings is highly relevant for global discussions. The authors discuss the adaptation of restrooms amid limited funds and mixed affective experiences of the university community.

Furthermore, articles in this special issue confront the binary opposition between exclusion and inclusion. They reframe this divide as a nuanced continuum of 'differential exclusion and inclusion' due to complex social, political, and cultural dynamics which place women 'both in and out of place at once, and in multiple contexts' (Shahrokni 2019, 125). This reframing acknowledges the inherent complexity of social belonging, recognising that each of us inhabits spaces where we simultaneously experience varying degrees of inclusion and exclusion. Nama'a Qudah's article investigates the layered intersecting meanings of 'insider' status and safety in the Palestinian Refugee Camp in Al Wehdat Camp in Amman, Jordan, through the symbolic and spatial roles of walls and streets, particularly on the lives, mobility, and agency of women in the camp and the gendering of the public camp spaces. This is related to the in-betweenness of spaces and identities wherein 'ambiguousness' in citizen identity and ambivalence in legal status of Palestinian refugees in Jordan places them under Jordanian governance as well as well as the control of the United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestinian Refugees. These ambivalences shape the Palestinians' everyday lives, including their relationship with public space, and constitute the 'permanent temporariness' of the camp by protracting the refugee status without a political solution in the near future.

Lemma and Spark's contribution also shows that while the Ethiopian migrant women derived a sense of home in Footscray from the presence of other migrants and access to Ethiopian cultural items, they simultaneously had to navigate male-dominated spaces in the neighbourhood where they felt unsafe, thus traversing feelings of both belonging and exclusion. This feeling is echoed in the article by Buket Özdemir Dal and Itır Aladağ Görentaş in which Syrian women refugees in Turkey report feeling welcome in some circumstances, while in others, their legal status of 'temporariness' along with their gender, ethnic, and refugee status render them at best 'tolerated' and at worst, marginalised and 'unwanted', thereby shaping their emotional engagement with public spaces.

Another relevant scholarly conversation has to do with the question of the gendered internet. While physical spaces have been central to research on gender and space, digital spaces are also the focus of scholarly and activist interrogation (Baer 2016; Chun 2016; Gajjala 2019; Phadke and Kanagasabai 2021). Beyond physical spaces, this encompasses virtual landscapes and conceptual territories where presence is asserted, contested, and negotiated. Wendy Chun (2016) draws on Phadke, Khan, and Ranade (2011) to ask what loitering might look like online. In thinking about the online, Chun suggests that in order to loiter online one would have to 'create technologies that acknowledge, rather than make invisible, the multitude of exchanges that take place around us – technologies that refuse the illusory boundary between audience and spectacle, author and character' (*ibid.*, 160). She suggests that in its very ephemerality, loitering has the potential to transform online 'open' private spaces into public spaces, and makes a case to build an internet which is truly public, one where we would inhabit networks differently.

Contributions in this special issue also interrogate digital spaces and show that digital spaces render themselves as not only political sites, but also as spaces for the mobilisation of emotions and affect that drive political discourse and challenge dominant representations (Shahrokni and Sofos 2022). In this issue, Heba Sigurdardottir, Majid Imani, and Zahra Edalati examine the 'Women-Life-Freedom' movement in Iran, focusing on how TikTok users harness their agency to politicise the platform and publicise their cause. They study 107 videos appearing under the hashtag #MahsaAmini, reflecting on embodied protest and affect and its impact on online mobilisation. It highlights that a moral obligation to care for others through embodied articulations in digital spaces could potentially shape a more caring transnational politics, wherein new political meanings are assigned and reassigned to public spaces and protests. Bronwen Mehta's paper examines the potential formation of a digital regional public space in the Middle East and North Africa, thereby challenging the hegemonic, western, and essentialist depictions of what constitutes a region, and asserting the multiple, contesting, and heterogeneous depictions of the 'Arab World'.

Re-engaging with public spaces as well as gendered interactions thus interrogates dichotomies and divides while allowing reinterpretations and political meanings to emerge. These engagements can be along historical as well as literary and cultural lines. Mahbubeh Moqadam presents an analysis of local historical accounts of women in Iran during the Naseri era (1848–1896) to show the richness, vibrancy, and nuances of their everyday lives, and their agency and engagement with social and political forces of the time, thereby producing 'alternative decolonial place-based feminist knowledge' (p. 149). By juxtaposing the portrayal of Iranian women's presence in public spaces in European travelogues and memoirs written by Iranian elite women, she demonstrates ways in which Iranian women were effectively written off from the western accounts of Iranian publics and public spaces. Similarly, Anuska Paul re-engages with women's agency and engagement with public space in Kabul, Afghanistan by locating literary texts in the larger context of geopolitics, the anti-Muslim/Islam climate post-9/11, and militarisation and securitisation post-9/11. Set during 2001–2014, she innovatively interweaves strands from creative texts to craft an image of Kabul that can coexist with neither the US-defined/homogenising notion of female Muslim victimhood, nor the opportunistic patriarchal local interests entrenched after four decades of war. Taking us to a different region, Vosloo examines how transatlantic slavery reinforced and normalised the association between blackness and placelessness in the context of Johannesburg, South Africa. She highlights how centring Black women's geographies and focusing our narratives on a Black feminist sense of place 'make visible social lives which are often displaced, rendered ungeographic' (p. 51). Her work underlines the importance of writing communities back into our (historical) accounts of public spaces. By examining public spaces through a social, cultural, political, and historical lens, many of the contributions reveal a rich tapestry of competing narratives, contested meanings, and evolving identities that defy simplistic and singular representation.

Everyday mapping and methods to make *other* spatialities

Historically maps have been ways of asserting colonial and racial dominance (Rose-Redwood et al. 2020; Sletto et al. 2021; Zaragocin and Caretta 2021). In urban planning too, maps have been ways to assert the power of the panoptic top-down gaze to make sense of the city. However, spaces are often inhabited in subversion of the planned paths and visions, and users literally write the streets and cities with their bodies, allowing for a creative and critical reimagining of space (DeCerteau 1988; Massey 1994). Maps also offer ways to think about spaces. They are methodologies that allow for a spatial and temporal understanding of the ways in which women and marginalised groups inhabit the public. They involve tracing and retracing paths to find one's way or lose oneself, and expose histories of violence, discrimination, and exclusion. Maps also allow for alternate histories of walking, navigating, and inhabiting to emerge. Mapping alternate ways of belonging to spaces also creates a new kind of visibility, the refusal of erasure, refusing convenient categorisations, and refusing to comply with top-down plans. These also pose methodological challenges, as some of these refusals are difficult to trace through conventional and hegemonic mapping practices.

Vosloo speaks of claiming spaces and knowledge by centring critical geographies from a Black feminist sense of place, thereby exposing oppressive aspects of traditional geography that render certain (Black) bodies and lives ungeographic and unseen. She makes an important methodological contribution in that she presents both a visual text and an academic text as sites of meaning-making, and disrupts the hierarchy of textual over visual by drawing from her art project. By connecting South African art through the work of Black female artists, urban narratives, and Black feminist geographies, this article represents a timely contribution to gender and urban space. Both Vosloo and Paul, through their work on Johannesburg and Kabul, attempt to make sense of places and of bodies that have been violated, robbed, bounded, extracted, dispossessed, bombed, plundered, and pillaged – resulting in identities and lives stolen and families and homes torn apart. Here the authors make connections between different decolonial feminist thinkers and artists to make sense of 'placelessness', blackness, gender, and movement/mobility to reclaim, remap, and suture their past and present. Lubinsky and Aultman forefront the placelessness or a sense of 'no place' that transgeographies reveal. They write, 'According to trans geographer Jack Gieseking, "trans geography is a geography of no place, because there has long been the idea (in media, politics, documents, geography, medicine, and so on) that trans people do not exist" (2023, 573)' (p. 396). This ties intimately with placelessness that Black geographies centre – the epistemology of being rendered 'ungeographic' which is shared by vulnerable bodies such as Syrian refugees in Turkey, as seen in Dal and Görentaş, and Palestinian refugees in the work of Qudah.

Mental maps also offer ways to discern the underlying power structures and show how public space is gendered (Ranade 2007; Ranade and Phadke 2023). Some articles delve further into mental maps by understanding the unique perspectives and affective experiences of young girls. Katsavounidou invited her students to remember their neighbourhoods at the age of 12 and to submit texts, maps, and drawings to understand the

gendered, classed, and regional specificities of the spaces, as they traced what it meant to transition from childhood to adolescence in urban and rural Greece. Similarly, Theocharides-Feldman and King examined young women's relationship to space in Trowbridge, Crewe, and Brent (UK), drawing attention to the infrastructure, parks, the street, furniture, textures, and how these shaped both the geographical spaces and young women's affective experiences of them.

Lemma and Spark's paper discusses mental maps of safety which steer bodies swiftly through places perceived as dangerous or unsafe. Their respondents mentioned changing paths, avoiding routes, and engaging in spatial practices that were informed by their experience of these localities. One of Abbas' respondents mentions planning in advance, '[making] conscious decisions about what areas are safe to go, instead of just getting up and going wherever you want'. In a similar vein, Qudah asks, 'Can streets and alleys be considered public spaces if one cannot stay in them, if one needs to continue moving? Are public spaces ones that allow a person to decide whether they want to move or stay? Are streets and alleys considered public spaces, if they feel unsafe, particularly to women, and because of that feeling of unsafety, women feel the need to move quickly through them, or avoid them altogether?' (p. 414). Authors of this special issue demonstrate that maps are more than just geo co-ordinates that mark physical spaces, and that emotions of belonging, unbelonging, fear as well as risks and play, lie embedded within them. The lessons one can draw from mental maps offer insights for 'urban policy and planning as well as for pedagogy in disciplines of social sciences and humanities in addition to the more obvious ones such as architecture, urban design and urban planning' (Ranade and Phadke 2023, 117).

'Feeling designed out': urban planning and gendered design

Architecture and design are central to the ways in which spaces are planned, structured, and produced. Scholarship on gendered public spaces has demonstrated just how influential architecture and design are to the experience of public spaces (da Costa Meyer 1996; Desai 2007; Hayden 1995; Ranade 2007; Rendell 2018; Torre 1996; Weisman 1992). Feminist geographers have contributed to our understanding of the ways in which gendered hierarchies and boundaries operate in space and place, and impact inhabitations and movement (Blidon and Zaragocin 2019; Domosh and Seager 2001; MacDowell 1999; Massey 1994, 2005; Rose 1993; Raju 2011). Urban planning is another discipline that tends to be visible when discussing questions of design (Falu 2014; Hayden 1980; Visakha 2021). Infrastructure and its design are central to creating spaces that are welcoming and usable for women and other marginal citizens. For women and other marginal citizens, public spaces are often full of reminders of various kinds that they do not belong. Engaging with public space often means dealing with hostile architecture, short-sighted urban policies, and urban planning that imagines a 'neutral user', 'neutral' in terms of gender, race or caste, physical ability, and sexuality, which inevitably caters to already-privileged groups (Ranade 2007). These concerns of access are compounded many times over for people with disabilities (Butler and Bowlby 1997; Lawson et al. 2022; Patrick and

McKinnon 2022; Pineda 2022; Stafford, Vanik, and Bates 2022). Women with disabilities experience double discrimination due to their gender and disability (Ghai 2018; Rodríguez-Garrido and Pino-Morán 2023). Invisibilising the questions of access and inclusion of people with disabilities is tantamount to derecognising the citizenship of disabled people. Unfortunately, this issue does not have a substantive engagement with disability.

The articles in this issue contribute to the debate on architecture, planning, and infrastructure, underscoring the exclusive nature of urban planning and design that result in many feeling excluded and 'designed out' (Theocharides-Feldman and King, p. 225). Caparrós mentions that women cab drivers had to negotiate the absence of public toilets as they navigated the streets while working. While men could relieve themselves anywhere, women had to drive to petrol pumps or shopping malls to use the toilet, which meant added time and financial costs. As one of her respondents call it, 'the drama of accessing toilets' was a regular challenge for the women and made them feel discriminated against/unwelcome to occupy public spaces (p. 299). Lubinsky and Aultman explore negotiating 'forbidden' desire and intimacy in public spaces and infrastructures that are often designed to be hostile towards queer bodies. They show that though physical infrastructure is mostly seen as being in the background, as passive, it actively mediates and shapes life practices and intimacies. The authors explore what is public, the spaces that hide within the public, and how masculinity – specifically queer trans masculinity – and erotics are felt within those spaces.

Ávila and Zamora collectively challenge exclusionary urban planning that privileges cars over people through a collaborative research praxis led by cycling collectives in the cities of Tijuana and Oaxaca, Mexico. They conceptualised this through *patriarcarro* that exposes the patriarchal and capitalist nature of transportation design and demonstrates the connection between road violence and wider violence against women. They also show via the collective initiatives of autonomous cycling organisations (mostly women-led), how urban mobility can be potentially reconfigured and reimagined by centring care, ecological sustainability, and inclusion.

Young girls' specific engagements with public space particularly for fun and play are unpacked by Katsavounidou and by Theocharides-Feldman and King who centre young girls' perspectives and experiences of feeling 'designed out' of the city. Theocharides-Feldman and King unpack the engagement of young women with spaces through 'judgement' of others and their own, and the ways in which this shapes how they use, occupy, and avoid certain spaces and objects. The design of these spaces and objects coupled with gender norms can ensure that certain bodies are 'designed out' (p. 225) from high-end shops, children's playgrounds, and even swings and benches. 'The dimensions of a bench may display who has a right to rest, pause, linger, and hang out, and the height and size of a swing may display how our society views the age limits of play' (p. 239). Interestingly, she uses the term 'caged youth playspace' to explain how current spaces of play are designed to be limited. This speaks to Katsavounidou's paper in which participants demand 'unprogrammed spaces', which were flexible and open to being repurposed for play. Young girls' preference for these 'unprogrammed spaces', which in urban

neighbourhoods can be an entrance staircase, the street, and the piloti of an apartment building serve as 'secret places' away from adults. 'All these memories highlight the girls' agency in shaping another 'public space', different from what is perceivable to adults and offers connection (instead of visible borders and fences), safety (instead of traffic danger and stranger danger) and, above all, a sense of belonging in a peer community ('these [secret places] were "ours"') (p. 215). Muchiri explains in her article 'The absence of safe/r spaces for young women is intentional and parallels the absence of other public goods for young women' (p. 484). Many of these spaces have been eaten into and hollowed out by planned urban development and neoliberal planning agendas.

Feminist scholarship and activism have pushed urban planning and policies to evolve to, in development lingo, 'mainstream gender' in city planning. While this is often critiqued as a token gesture, the feminist philosophy that drives it must be considered seriously. These gestures can become much larger, affording possibilities of creating spaces that aspire to be feminist. Charmain Levy and Lilian Celiberti's paper reflects on the functioning of the Plaza las Pioneras in Montevideo, Uruguay, a space that is intended as a feminist urban commons. They argue that though the space is designed as participatory, in order for it to be effectively feminist, feminisms at the local and regional levels must be strengthened. They envisage the space as one that is in the process of commoning. This feminist plaza and the implicit connection between feminist claims and the commons then enable a conversation on collective ownership, citizenship, and democratic public spaces.

Spaces that might be seen as commons, or even as feminist commons, raise other important concerns: How does the presence of such feminist commons challenge neoliberal visions of recreation? What are the ways in which such spaces reinforce the recognition of women as citizens with rights to not just occupy public spaces but to design and reimagine them. In what ways does feminism as a philosophical frame shape urban planning, access, and ecology, and how does it enable us to think about cities differently though a politics and practice of care? These questions offer new ways to think about collaborations – that are by no means smooth but by their very roughness and fraught nature hold the possibilities of a solidarity that is negotiated and dynamic, never arrived at but always in a state of arriving.

Cultivating solidarity, care, fun, and friendships in physical and digital spaces

How do we think of fun especially for those for whom the public is often unsafe, and even dangerous? Protests and resistance in claims to public space have often produced solidarities that are rooted in a politics of care where there is recognition, acknowledgement, and empathy for each other. Fun, far from being a neoliberal construct, can be seen as facilitating subversive possibilities that allow for citizenship claims in ways that do not eschew humour, laughter, and enjoyment. These are integral to seeing public spaces as spaces of possibility, of joy and expansive engagement.

Access to leisure, much less 'frivolous' fun, is rarely part of what are considered serious conversations on gendered public spaces. In relation to second-generation, Palestinian

refugees in Beirut, Khalili (2016) points out that their quest for fun in public space, even when it is on private beaches, needs to be seen through a more complex lens than one that merely ascribes these as neoliberal individualistic pleasures. Similarly, work in South Asia, separately in both India and Pakistan, argues that fun is integral to an understanding of public space that is rooted in citizenship (Kirmani 2020; Phadke 2020). Phadke, Khan, and Ranade (2011) make a case for fun and 'loitering' as feminist politics of access to public space. In building their arguments, they ask who is having fun in public space and suggest that most women strategise inordinately in order to access public space for fun. The call to loiter is rooted in horizontal citizenship, everyone, including those deemed to be a threat to women should have the right to loiter as citizens.

Several papers in this issue speak to these concerns that bring fun and resistance together. These include instances of young girls carving out spaces within the city considered unsafe to play, protestors and migrants having fun despite occupying precarious positions, and women cycling in the face of *patriarcarro*. These are all acts of defiance and refusal in the face of systematic exclusion and exploitation. Fernandez shows that by occupying market spaces, churches, and self-organised picnics, Ethiopian domestic workers in Lebanon challenge the typical employer perception that 'migrant domestic workers are in the country to work and not to have fun'. In these spaces, they challenge the norms that constrain them, though not without discrimination in some spaces like malls.

A survey at the University of Buenos Aires, Argentina, shows 'eating, resting, smoking, talking with classmates or colleagues, and even crying' are needs for the university community that take place during 'downtime'/idle time. Spaces for napping, and the above-mentioned experiences/activities emerged as a demand in the survey (Flesler and Spataro). Taneja finds that in the context of restricted access to public spaces for leisure, girls and women of Khaliyai Mandi in Agra spend '*faltu*' (idle) time in courtyards or terraces. While this is a time and space wherein bonds of sociality are built, it is interesting to note that even in this '*faltu*' time, they are not really 'idle' but engage in income-generating activities.

Daniela Vicherat Mattar's work forefronts care as fundamental to sustaining life (individual, human–non-human, city, and planet). Through three vignettes of street art during the citizen protests in Santiago in 2019, she stretches the limits and definitions of '(disobedient)' acts of citizenship by encompassing care as an act of 'public making'. She discusses the intersections between feminism and ecological concerns as a critical response to the interlocked structures of colonialism, capitalism, and patriarchy which exploit bodies, territories, and the planet. Cyclist groups in Mexico used cycling to create community, carve counter-publics, cultivate care, friendship and solidarity, and resist exclusionary planning and infrastructural and transportation violence (Avila and Zamora). Through their engagement with the Plaza las Pioneras in Uruguay, Levy and Celeberti show the ways in which community, care, and ecological sustainability can be integrated into feminist planning, which can seriously challenge neoliberal logics of urban planning and living.

Some of the papers gesture towards similar possibilities for bonds that might be seen as friendship or friendship-like emerging. Caparrós highlights the experience of women taxi

and platform-based drivers in the city of Malaga, Spain in navigating a male-dominated profession and space. While the article discussed experiences of fear and sexual harassment among women drivers, it also examines how the presence of women drivers at night provided a sense of safety and social support for other women who are out in public spaces. These cab drivers spoke of a sense of responsibility towards all women. 'For example, participants often highlighted that when they take women back home at night, they always wait at the door until they see them going inside safely. It is common among taxi drivers to wait for women clients while they get their keys, open the door, and get inside the building' (p. 304). While this could be understood under the framework of care, the author interprets this as a form of social reproductive labour.

Solidarity, care, and friendships have formed in physical and digital spaces at local, regional, and global scales. These solidarities traverse the engagements between bodies, femininity, state, nation, and the world – all being digitally mediated to produce transnational publics. The last two decades have witnessed global and local feminist movements and conversations in the global South(s). These movements have engendered dynamic conversations that have been celebratory and critical in turn. Some of these include the slut-walks that began in Canada in 2011, the feminist performance, 'A Rapist in Your Path' that began in Chile in 2019, and the 'Zan, Zendegi, Azadi' protests that began in 2022 in Iran. More localised protests that nonetheless have travelled digitally include the 'Aurat March' that takes place every year in various cities in Pakistan starting from 2018 and the 'Why Loiter' movement that began in India in 2014 and has been read as feminist performance protest (Lieder 2018). Feminist solidarities of all kinds are fractured in various ways by global South–North divides, by racial and caste inequalities, by divisions of gender and gender binaries, as well as by differences in nuanced positions and local contexts (Kanagasabai and Phadke 2023). National, regional, and transnational digital publics and solidarity are present in the articles by Mehta and by Sigurdardottir et al. and potentially pave the way for wider feminist mobilisations that challenge normative 'transnational', global discourse in creative ways.

Challenging erasures through art and creative theorisations

The public-space body is one that for women is largely marked by erasure. Sociospatial transformations driven by neoliberal planning policies result in the marginalisation, and even obliteration of certain bodies, experiences, and histories. Contributions illustrate these through the effacement of young girls' needs from physical planning of cities in the UK and Greece; erasure and sanitising of visual protest culture in the form of street art in Santiago to fit with the neoliberal city; the continued devaluation, discrimination, and dehumanisation of Black bodies who work and live near the toxic decommissioned mineslopes in Johannesburg; and the obliteration of massive parts of the country's physical and symbolic history in Kabul by foreign and local power holders. Upon returning to the Palestinian refugee camp a couple of years after her research, Qudah found that the women's centre which served as a refuge for women to rest, heal, talk, and a space for their children to play was demolished and relocated to one of the floors of a newly

constructed multi-floor complex. It was clear that this small oasis was swallowed by the forces of capital. 'Where would the women socialise and how would they be able to enjoy the sky, if a thick concrete ceiling like everywhere in the camp, blocked their view and hung over their heads? Was it still a public space, were they still outside if they were inside a room, with no sky? (Qudah, p. 431).

What does it mean when spaces that are intended to allow for creative interpretations are moved into enclosed buildings where possibilities are limited?

Despite attempts to exclude and/or regulate women and queer bodies, there is everyday resistance to such invisibilisation. Contributions in this issue challenge and subvert the narrative of the death and erasure of the city and its marginalised inhabitants through embodied acts of walking, archiving, excavating, and writing. These radical and everyday acts of remembering forgotten lives and labour offer what Vosloo refers to as 'livingness' in the face of death.

Avila and Zamora combine ethnographic and creative writing methods to produce an online repository of collective lived experiences of cycling communities and ways in which they navigate, reclaim, and reappropriate streets in Mexico's cities. Mattar employs 'aesthetic activism' to unpack connections between feminism and ecology while Kai Mata et al. deploy pride from a decolonial and intersectional lens, wherein queerness and ethnic minority positions are both celebrated, despite their marginalisation in public spaces. 'Celebrating Pride goes hand in hand with protesting against hegemonic oppression, racism, the caste system, heteronormative patriarchy, and Sinhala-Buddhist supremacy' (p. 382). Lubinsky and Aultman forefront the often invisibilised and silenced experiences of trans, queer, and Black persons, and amplify their desire and grief through art. They aver, 'Consider, again, Bey (2019, 66): "To grieve and lament publicly, loudly, is a testament to the insistence on the mattering of Black life, Black queer life, Black trans life; it is a refusal to let the dead die"' (p. 407). Through art, activism, pride, and protests, they offer livingness and memory in the face of dehumanisation, disposability, and death. By deploying a creative agency, they unleash a collective refusal to be erased, forgotten, exploited, and dehumanised.

Creative theorisations are thus an important way to think about the intersections of public space and gender. The creative ways in which women and other gender- and sexually minoritised communities respond to attempts of their symbolic and material erasures offer critical frameworks to understand resistances. While it is crucial to tend to the resistive energies of engagement with space, as various contributions to this special issue do, it is equally urgent to tend to the languages of the imagination deployed to make, remake, and re-energise public space and meanings associated with publicness.

To fully take the creative seriously is to understand that it exceeds the repertoire of response, to create something new. Tending to such energies and effects as more than responses and subversions reveals the multiple avenues of creative theorisation (Gqola 2008, 2011; Khan 2018; Khan, Asfour, and Skeyi-Tutani 2022), and the 'series and forms of conjecture, speculative possibilities opened up in literary and other creative genres' (Gqola 2008, 50). Creative strategies, languages, and grammars variously access imaginative and theoretical possibilities unavailable to genres more preoccupied with

linearity and exactness. It is through these that certain articulations of freedom are brought into being. Creative theorisation exposes the limits of historical valuation in the absence of a dependable, capacious narrative. More important than reciting the fact of history's selective constructedness is the creative wrestling with the possibilities of feminist memoried construction, and a demand that the imagination perform differently.

Creative theorisation can be gleaned in several essays in this collection. Vosloo's article traces the rhetorics through which Marasela fashions an embodied language to synthesise competing presences, longings, fantasies, and unmourned erasures. The paper argues that focusing on the violence that is the context of Marasela's artworks does her projects a disservice. It misses the artist's painstaking attention to crafting a different language than one of resistance and woundedness. We are invited to wonder about the place of repetition of the artist's own body standing in for another and the invocation of another feminist artist similarly concerned with crafting a language capacious enough to speak through Black women's experiences, without spectacularising violence, romanticising their survival, or denying them mourning, what Goliath (2019) has called a 'necessary and sustained irresolution'. In resisting narratorial tidiness, through the enmeshment of trajectory and fragment (Gqola 2008; Khan 2018; Ligaga 2020; Moji 2023), creative theorisation can 'chart new ways in which meaning might be further harnessed by placing the creative and the explicitly critical alongside one another' (Gqola 2011, 5).

Paul's treatment of two creative texts also tends to creative theorisation and responds, in part, to the confluence of hegemonic constructions of Kabul, adopting the postures of women walking the street as a way of thinking, revisiting, and remaking Afghan histories of access between 2000 and 2014. The paper acknowledges the layered histories, some imposed through spectacular violence, others through more codified imprint, to ask, 'how does this cycle of destruction, construction, and reconstruction shape the history of a place such as Kabul?' (p. 96). Leaning into the question, Paul is interested in how violence structures the 'spatio-geographical landscape of post-2001 Kabul' (p. 97), and creatively theorise a different way in which to gender Kabul away from US imperialist feminist constructions of the docile Muslim woman as well as patriarchal Afghan nationalist memory. The modes through which these texts complicate space dovetail with Carole Boyce-Davies' (1994) 'migratory subjectivities', wherein women's imaginative products deploy mobility across space and time in ways that trouble received understandings of such women's proper patriarchal place. Creative strategies are thus at play in Paul's essay, since the walking protagonists access history, enact 'clandestine pleasure', and rewrite new meanings of publicness and publicity, by variously gesturing to hidden prior relationships between women and place.

The reappearance of walking as a trope in imaginative mnemonic reworking of gendered space and experience comes as no surprise given the increase in attention to walking as a processing strategy in feminist literary and cultural studies scholarship. Polo Moji's (2023) excellent tracing of how marginalised women's urban walking patterns can be read as a mediation and interruption of their marking as 'out of place' reads particularly well alongside Feldman and King's contribution which confronts the

eliminatory processes through which women are designed out of value and conceptions of public space. Moji extends Katherine McKittrick's 'who we see is tied up with where we see' and therefore that 'the placement of subaltern bodies deceptively hardens spatial binaries, in turn suggesting that some bodies belong, and some bodies are out of place' (McKittrick 2006, xv). Linking the imaginative value of the walking woman beyond the symbolic, Saidiya Hartman's idea of the strolling Black woman figure in creative rendition is herself 'a long poem' of striving and a 'map of the *might could* or *what might be*' as both 'an everyday choreography of the possible' made through the insistence of a woman's 'errant path' (Hartman 2019, 468). Crucially, then, when Moji crafts an analytical framework of 'walking as method' for making sense of flâneuse mobility, she enables a different sense-making. Here, strolling becomes the way in which subaltern women negotiate qualified belonging and citizenship by remapping and repurposing public space as well as their stake within it across contemporary, imaginary, and historical epochs (Moji 2023).

Articles also invoke creative spaces where emotions dwell, where desire, possibility, and hope come to co-exist, as well as where colonial, racist, and normative understandings of queerness, transness, and liminality are interrogated and challenged. Lubinsky and Aultman discuss the dialogic space between 'fantasy/fantasmic' realms of queer desire and the 'ordinary' spaces and lives of the everyday where 'trans ordinary' dwells. They bring forth trans infrastructures which allow desires to be articulated and serve as oases of refuge, even escape amid queer and transphobic landscapes. Contributions discuss waiting and hope – waiting to go home, feel at home, and waiting for homes to be rebuilt, waiting for love, and waiting to be reunited with family. The 'third space', a concept that is summoned in some articles, is utilised as a conceptual territory that houses these hopes and desires. Walls, streets, swings, benches, *thinna*, bridges, queer bars, narrative spaces, as well as acts of walking and cycling are thus infused with meaning, resistances, and agency by women and queer communities. In these ways, the realm of fantasy, story, and works of the imagination shape people's engagements with public spatial and temporal possibility. Rather than playing a supplementary role, imaginative rendering works to experiment and produce infrastructures of possibility.

Concluding reflections

Working on this issue has been an exciting exercise of collaboration and horizontal comradeship across disciplines and regions and inevitably time zones, as we met when one person was having their morning coffee and another about to get their dinner. It has meant trying to think with each other, and to think alongside each other, to imagine parallel and intersecting ways of engaging and editing. We have not always agreed with each other but our disagreements have been productive, generative, and attended by care. This special issue, we hope, is one that advances in some measure not just the scholarship on gender and public space but also ways of seeing and researching it.

This special issue has sought to demonstrate the regional and geographical width, the theoretical depth, and the creative heights of an expanding body of work on gender and public space. Even as we have hoped in this special issue to approach gender and public spaces from newer theoretical and inter-disciplinary locations to offer fresh understandings and pave ways for creative research, we recognise that this is already a significant field in itself and perhaps also has something of its own canon. Working on this issue has reinforced the awareness of the tremendous research and growing body of work on gender and public space as evidenced by the fact that we received more than 700 abstracts. Reading through these and selecting only some was challenging and inevitably some promising and exciting abstracts could not be included. Though we tried hard to include a wide range of themes focusing on those that are more pressing in a contemporary world, some important themes are missing in this issue despite our best efforts.

Caste is a significant and relatively understudied element of how women, especially oppressed caste women, experience public space (Ayyar 2013, 2017). While Aftab et al. explore the exclusions that women sanitary workers in Lahore, Pakistan, face, there is no paper in this issue that looks specifically at caste in India where perhaps the oppressions of caste are most visible and pressing. Unfortunately, two papers that focused on caste, gender, and access to public space that had been commissioned were withdrawn fairly late in the process such that they could not be replaced with other papers engaging with caste centrally. Disability is another critical layer of exclusion, discrimination, and inaccessibility in public space and design, and though it is represented through rich scholarship globally, we acknowledge its grave absence in this special issue. Religion and religious ideologies are often used to control women's movement and access to public space, and though a few contributions discuss these, a detailed analysis of religion and public space remains understudied in the issue.

At the same time, many contributions in this issue contribute to emerging areas of scholarship such as feminist fun, friendships, and *faltupan* (idleness) by women in rural and urban contexts. Others add further value to public activism by integrating care, ecological sustainability, and solidarity, while deploying 'demonic' feminist methodologies (Vosloo), 'disobedient' citizenship (Mattar), and 'subversive invisibility' (Bednarczyk) to carve alternative geographies. Contributions also point to certain gaps in scholarship on gender and public space such as voices of rural women, young people, and children, which are often marginalised. The often under-theorised perspectives of childhood and adolescence, the unique marginalisations they face, and the right of young populations to have a legitimate share in occupying and claiming public spaces have been addressed in this issue. Affective and emotional energies that shape the experiences of people with spaces have found representation in this issue. Many authors in this issue illustrate that creative theorisations challenge the normative framings of despair, drudgery, desperation, and death, most associated with marginalised lives, to reveal hope, dreams, desires, and celebration. Contributions thus bring forth fresh inter-disciplinary collaborations between Philosophy, Feminist and Trans Geographies, Ecology, Fiction, and Literature, which enable creative theorisations to take seed. These collaborations help bring theoretical discussions closer to art, policy, and activism, and strengthen citizenship claims.

The question that many papers also hold at their core is how do we build solidarities in a time when the world is divided, when globally governments and other bodies are acting to create ruptures rather than collaborations. They demonstrate that *creating social change is a spatial matter* that must engage with social justice activism and deeply collaborative research through *collective* feminist activist geographies (Zaragocin et al. 2023). This brings us to the question of 'infrastructures of possibilities' (Lubinsky and Aultman, p. 406). Could spaces be imagined differently so that leisure, fun, rest, and respite become not just mere components but central principles undergirding planning and policy discourse? Would more shade, trees, and benches enable women in the gig economy to relax in between shifts, share a meal, and a chat with others, giving them some respite from the labour demands of the city? Would children be able to claim spaces for play? Can sexually and gender-minoritised groups assert their right to public space without fear? Articles in the special issue stress that community, care, and ecological sustainability must be integrated into the planning and design of public spaces in order to challenge neoliberal and extractive logics, oppression, and violence that constitute the making of urban publics, and reinscribe newer meanings to publics, public spaces, and publicness.

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